

Chapter 44-1: Fluffy

The half-reclining Chu Qingqiu seemed to choke on something, covering her lips as she coughed until her eyes became watery. Jiang Li quickly stepped forward to help, but was blocked by Chu Qingqiu's raised hand.

"I apologize. I've always loved joking around. Please don't take it to heart, Divine Venerable," Jiang Li said, reaching out to stroke her back. "But I didn't mean it that way either. I just felt that the Young Sect Leader's attitude toward you is different from what the rumors say."

Only after her breathing calmed did Chu Qingqiu shake her head, lamplight flickering in her eyes.

"She barely has time to hate me," she said softly.

"Thank you for today, Medical Immortal. Tomorrow..."

Having wandered the martial world for so many years, Jiang Li had seen all kinds of people. Although she loved prying into secrets, she naturally knew there were some matters one shouldn't ask too much about. So she picked up the bundle full of silver needles from the bed: "Divine Venerable, please rest well. I'll come again tomorrow. With daily internal cultivation plus medicinal baths, I believe you'll recover completely within a month."

After saying this, she bowed and was led to the guest room by an immortal attendant. Chu Qingqiu stared blankly for a while, then looked toward the window.

Downstairs was pitch black—no one was there anymore.

Ning Fuyi had indeed circled outside the door several times, wanting to find out about Chu Qingqiu's condition. Only after finally seeing a figure appear at the window did she breathe a sigh of relief and leave Tranquil Mountain Palace.

The moon was bright and stars were sparse. Except for Tranquil Mountain Palace, which didn't like lighting lamps, other palaces and pavilions all had scattered lights dotting the shadows of trees, gentle and serene.

Having slept for several days and nights, Ning Fuyi wasn't sleepy at all. Instead of hurrying back to Pearl Radiance Pavilion, she turned toward the library pavilion called "Can't Read Anymore,"¹ planning to flip through some books to see if there were any ancient texts recording demon clan history.

Although she had cultivated demon arts in her previous life, by that time the demon clan had already fallen apart, long since losing the glory they had when Jun Mo Lan was alive tens of thousands of years ago. Only when she, the "Heaven-Punishing Divine Demon," appeared did the demon clan begin to revive.

Currently, the demon clan was still in decline, and looking toward the future, there wasn't anyone in the entire demon cave who could match her. So no matter how she thought about it, she couldn't figure out where that demon clan member from the Divine Meteorite had come from.

The library pavilion was very quiet—a three-story building. Upon entering, there were several zhang-high giant bookcases arranged in four rows from left to right. The high places couldn't be seen clearly with the naked eye; one had to climb wooden ladders to continue browsing.

Bronze perpetual lamps were embedded in the walls and bookcases, illuminating all the scrolls.

Ning Fuyi searched according to categories for a long time, occasionally finding a few demon clan secret scrolls, but they only talked about things from halfway through history—nothing she didn't already know.

Seeing the moon being covered by clouds, she was getting dizzy from reading and had to put down the bamboo scroll in her hands to rub her eyes.

Just then, she suddenly heard a sound. Her mind sharpened as she quickly looked toward where the noise came from. There, half a robe corner was visible. She had been searching for so long without noticing—the other person's cultivation must be far above hers.

"Who's there?" she asked in a low voice. No one answered, but a feather duster rolled out, clattering to a stop behind the bookcase.

The divine sword appeared before her at just the right time. Ning Fuyi grasped it and slowly walked forward. Only then did the person hiding behind the bookcase slowly emerge—wearing cloth clothes, his white beard covering his entire face, leaning against the wall with his legs stretched out, sleeping so soundly he was oblivious to heaven and earth.

Ning Fuyi sighed in relief, put the divine sword away, gently picked up the feather duster from the ground, and placed it aside.

The Chief Elder suddenly let out a long snore, humming as he opened his eyes. Those cloudy pupils glanced at Ning Fuyi and suddenly revealed blackened teeth: "Little Changfeng, ah."

Ning Fuyi paused, then shook her head: "Elder, I'm Ning Fuyi, not Ning Changfeng."

"Where's Changfeng?" the Chief Elder asked drowsily.

"Mother has passed away," Ning Fuyi answered patiently.

"Oh." The Chief Elder was really quite old. He stared with open eyes for quite a while before fully waking up, using his hand to scratch his beard twice and slowly sitting up.

"Why are you sleeping here?" Ning Fuyi couldn't help asking. In her previous life, the Chief Elder had always been either in deep sleep or in seclusion, rarely awake. So she actually hadn't interacted much with him, only knowing that he had lived for a very, very long time. After she became a demon, this elder had finally passed away.

"Mm, I dreamed of some past events from your mother's youth. Back then, this old man was considered half her teacher," the Chief Elder said with difficulty, picking up the feather duster and tucking it at his waist. He raised his drooping eyelids to look at Ning Fuyi. "You really do resemble your mother. In my confusion, I actually mistook you for her."

Ning Fuyi said nothing, only touched her own face.

She had always felt that many people understood Ning Changfeng better than she did herself.

"Disciple presumes to ask you about some matters," Ning Fuyi crouched beside him, speaking straightforwardly. "How many years have you lived?"

She had thought this question would be offensive, but when the Chief Elder heard it, his cloudy eyes immediately widened, as if he had never been so alert in his entire life.

"When this old man cultivated to the Great Vehicle realm², your mother was still just a little girl," he chuckled merrily. "From the divine realm above to the underworld below, there's nothing this old man hasn't heard of. Whatever questions you have, just ask."

That was perfect! Ning Fuyi said joyfully: "Chief Elder, do you know if among the demon clan after Divine Venerable Chu Ling emerged, there was anyone who could contend with her?"

"The demon clan..." the Chief Elder stroked his beard thoughtfully. "Ever since that Jun Mo Lan fell, the demon clan's influence greatly diminished. For ten thousand years, they haven't made much of a splash."

"Except for that ancient evil spirit that emerged a thousand years ago," the Chief Elder seemed to remember something and added.

Ning Fuyi's heartstrings trembled as she quickly pressed: "What kind of being was that evil spirit? Wasn't it said to have died at the hands of my mother and the Divine Venerable?"

"The evil spirit had no name, but it came from ancient times. Its power was strange and vast—in an instant, it could overturn heaven and earth, bringing devastation to all living beings. At that time, the five great sects and four great families joined forces, even including the Penglai Realm³, but they still couldn't destroy it."

"Back then, your mother had just broken through to the Great Vehicle realm. Full of youthful ambition and high spirits, she planned to seek out that evil spirit to slay demons and save the world. Halfway there, she encountered the Divine Venerable who had come from who knows where, and the two became acquainted."

"At that time, the Divine Venerable wasn't yet a Divine Venerable—there wasn't even half a mention of her name in the martial world. Your mother was also bold, feeling it was fate and kept pestering her."

"Your mother was that kind of person—grabbing a long spear and charging at anything, as if she feared nothing. It's said the Divine Venerable was quite annoyed by her, but she didn't care at all. Fortunately, she met the Divine Venerable, otherwise with her cultivation level at the time, she would surely have died."

"No one knows clearly what happened that day. They only know that half the sky was covered with clouds for three days, and afterward the evil spirit dissipated, returning peace to all living beings. You know the rest of what happened after that."

After saying these few sentences, the Chief Elder seemed exhausted as if he was about to faint. He took out a pill from his sleeve and swallowed it before recovering his energy and continuing: "However, that evil spirit was from a thousand years ago. After it dissipated, it never appeared again. Why do you suddenly ask—is it because of the incident at Zhaoyao Mountain?"

Ning Fuyi was still immersed in what he had just said, only nodding when she heard this.

"These matters aren't for a young girl like you to worry about. The sect leaders and elders of those sects are there to handle it. The immortal realm is full of outstanding talents—why worry?" the Chief Elder waved his hand.

"Yes," Ning Fuyi replied. She wanted to say more, but when she looked down, he had already fallen asleep again and was snoring.

Ning Fuyi closed her mouth. She found a large sheet of paper to cover him with before leaving the library pavilion.

This trip wasn't in vain—at least she had heard the complete story of Chu Qingqiu and Ning Changfeng. It seemed their acquaintance was also something her mother had forced. Ning Fuyi slowly walked down the steps.

As for who that man really was, she would need to keep watch in the future.

After thinking this through, she summoned her divine sword and flew back to Pearl Radiance Pavilion on it.

The following days were very peaceful, like a gentle stream flowing quietly. So peaceful that sometimes Ning Fuyi would have the illusion that the events of her previous life were becoming blurred, and she really was still the Ning Fuyi who had never entered the demon path.

Every day she rested, practiced morning cultivation, and attended classes at Suspended Beam Garden together with the other disciples. Although no one yet knew about her greatly increased cultivation, because of the changes in attitude from senior disciples like Feng Ge and Hong Ying, her days at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate became surprisingly pleasant. Other disciples still thought her cultivation was low, but their attitudes had completely changed.

Ever since sleeping for several days and nights without feeling hunger, Ning Fuyi was surprised to discover that her body had somehow learned to abstain from grains⁴, making her somewhat like a real cultivator.

Moreover, through continuous practice, the divine sword could now follow commands from her spiritual consciousness. Although after each practice session the divine sword would nuzzle against her, there had been considerable progress overall.

Footnotes:

- ¹ **"Can't Read Anymore"** (读不下去) - A humorous name for the library, suggesting it's filled with boring or difficult texts.
- ² **Great Vehicle realm** (大乘) - One of the higher cultivation realms in the story's power system, representing advanced spiritual achievement.
- ³ **Penglai Realm** (蓬莱境) - A mystical realm in Chinese mythology, often associated with immortals and magical islands.
- ⁴ **Abstain from grains** (辟谷) - A cultivation practice where advanced practitioners no longer need to eat regular food, sustaining themselves on spiritual energy instead.